while the variations in the Buddhist tradition about the number of monarchs after Ashoka range between two and five.[2] Evidently, those who ruled in the decades after Ashoka did not manage to emulate the long reigns of the first three emperors of the line. The *Puranas* are unanimous that Maurya dynastic suzerains ruled for some 137 years. So if the first three—Chandragupta, Bindusara, and Ashoka—account for some 85 years, the later Mauryas will have ruled for only 52. Whether there were three or seven rulers who shared this half century from *circa* 232 BCE to 180 BCE, each will have followed his predecessor far more quickly than did the big three.[3]

Still, some ancient Indian kings seem to have managed to do a great deal to be remembered by in their short reigns of eight to ten years. Pulumavi, the last king of the later Andhra Satavahana dynasty, ruled for only seven years (*c*. 226–232 CE) but is known by the coins that he struck, from inscriptions issued in his time as a shrine builder, and as a monarch who ruled over large parts of Maharashtra and Karnataka.[4] Naturally, one imagines that the kings who succeeded Ashoka made a range of interventions as they administered their patrimony. But what these interventions were or who they patronized, and whether Ashoka's legacy of humane governance was followed or jettisoned by them, are issues that don't figure in contemporaneous sources. Most of the later Mauryas remain mere names, unknown in the sources of the late centuries BCE and only rarely appearing as rounded historical subjects in later texts.

The *Ashokavadana's* list typically underlines this when the seven kings succeeding Ashoka are mentioned thus: 'Sampadin's son was Brhaspati who, in turn, had a son named Vrsasena, and Vrsasena had a son named Pusyadharman, and Pusyadharman begot Pusyamitra.'[5] Sampadin, it has been suggested, was the same as the Samprati mentioned in Jaina literature. He featured some pages ago, in the account of Ashoka's unhappy last years, as inheritor of the kingdom. In Jaina literature, on the other hand, Samprati